

ACCESS ENABLED
A student reaches out for a book in the library of a CM RISE school in Bhopal

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blighted by poor quality. The annual status of education report (ASER) by Pratham, an NGO that works in the education sector, corroborates this. The report on learning trends in MP between 2012-2018 (pre-Covid) found that while there was a marginal improvement in the percentage of class II students who could read designated texts (story level) from 2.7 per cent in 2012 to four per cent in 2018, there was a regression in reading ability. While in 2012, 64.6 per cent students in class VIII could read text for class II students, this fell to 57.9 per cent in 2018.

The public education sector in MP is marred by a legacy of politics, recruitment scams, low-quality teachers and the government's reluctance to take corrective steps. But with quality education now on the political agenda, MP CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan gave a go ahead to the CM RISE concept in March 2020 after he returned for a fourth term.

The school education department began the process for putting in place the CM RISE schools project by integrating primary, middle and secondary schools in one campus as this prevents students from dropping out. A national design competition was organised and 31 architects chosen to design the schools. The government used data analytics with variables such as land and infrastructure availability and enrolment to decide the schools' locations, finally shortlisting 15,000 places, which have been scaled down to 9,200.

Pre-primary classes have been introduced in the state (most states don't have them in government schools) through CM RISE Schools. Also, teachers and principals have been given a handbook to follow. "Learning has been made quantifiable, as teachers have to make lesson plans and know if students have learnt what has been taught. Even disciplinary rules have been made, clarifying what is to be done in case of transgressions," says principal secretary, school education, Rashmi Arun Shami. For selecting teachers, applications were invited and tests were held. "The idea is to get teachers with a higher skill set and commitment level," she added. Principals and teachers are being trained at IIM Indore. The schools have smart classrooms, laboratories,

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> **– RASHMI ARUN SHAMI,** *Principal Secretary, Department of School Education, MP*